

Between Irony and Indictment: Exploring the Discursive Dimensions of Social AI Interpretations of Politicized COVID-19 Imagery

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Goals and Research Questions

Goals

General: Approach multimodal communication from a corpus-based perspective, which depends on access to large collections of multimodal data (Berber Sardinha, 2021, 2023, 2024, 2025; Collins & Baker, 2023). To make these collections analyzable, visual, auditory, gestural, or kinetic features must be annotated in a form suitable for corpus processing. AI now offers a possible means for large-scale automated conversion of multimodal data into textual representations, thereby enabling their integration into corpus-based workflows.

1. Understand how LLMs distinguish between objective and subjective image description, given their internal knowledge and training data.
2. Determine how far the accompanying text can influence the LLM interpretation.

Research Questions

RQ1 What are the discourses underlying the image descriptions?

RQ2 How do the different prompt conditions (objective, subjective, subjective with tweet) differ along each dimension?

Previous Study: Visual Discourses of the Pandemic

- We build on previous studies (Romeiro et al., 2023, 2024) that analyzed a corpus of 38,459 images from tweets containing the term *genocida* (“genocidal”), all posted during the COVID-19 pandemic.
- The discourse dimensions from these studies were used as a sampling criterion for the current corpus.

Corpus Size

Condition	Texts	Words	Avg.
Objective	907	95413	105.2
Subjective	907	185849	204.9
Subj. w/ tweet	907	224259	247.3
Overall	2721	505521	185.8

Table: Corpus size

Post #15963

2021-02-26; translation

Avoid institutional rupture.  Collor asked for yellow-green support, but population took to the streets wearing black/92 Bolsonaro discourages use of face masks, let's take it to the streets urgently against genocide. For our safety, we will wear protection gear. With the right protection, we can do it/2021 <https://t.co/pynrqImarX>

2021-02-26; original

EVITAR RUPTURA INSTITUCIONAL.  Collor pediu apoio em verde-amarelo, mas população saiu às ruas de preto/92 BOLSONARO DESESTIMULA USO D MÁCARA, OCUPAR AS RUAS (MANIFESTAR) URGENTE CONTRA O GENOCIDA. P/NOSSA GARANTIA, IREMOS PARAMENTADOS SEM RISCO. C/TODA PROTEÇÃO, NÓS PODEMOS/2021 <https://t.co/PynrqIMARX>



GPT Descriptions of Post #15963

Subj. with Tweet; Score=10.000

The image shows an individual dressed in protective medical gear, which includes a facemask, face shield, gloves, and a disposable gown. The person is pointing with both hands, suggesting directions or guidance. The expression on the person's face, partially covered by the mask, looks serious and focused, effectively **underscoring** the **urgency** and gravity conveyed in the accompanying tweet. The tweet itself references significant political unrest and health **concerns**, drawing parallels between historical political demonstrations and current events (as of 2021) related to the COVID-19 pandemic and the actions (or

Subjective; Score=25.000

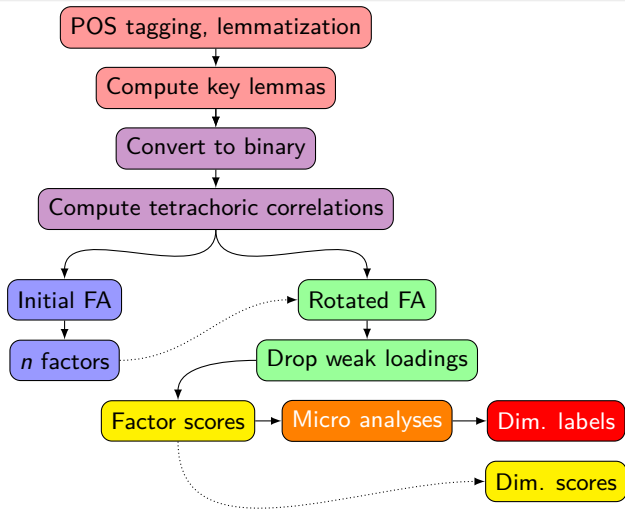
The image portrays a healthcare worker dressed in protective gear, including a face mask, face shield, gloves, and a disposable gown. The worker's expression, though obscured by the mask, appears focused and serious, possibly indicative of the gravity and **urgency often experienced** by medical professionals, **especially** during health **crises** like the COVID-19 pandemic. Emotionally, the image can **evoke feelings** of **reassurance** and **trust**, as it **highlights** the thorough precautions being taken to **ensure safety** and cleanliness.

Objective; Score=-6.000

This image features an individual dressed in protective medical gear against a plain, light background. The person is wearing a white coverall, blue gloves, a face mask, face shield, and a hairnet. They are pointing with both hands towards different directions and looking directly at the camera. The overall setting suggests a clinical or health **safety** environment.

Lexical MD Analysis

Berber Sardinha and Fitzsimmons-Doolan (2025)



GPT Dimensions

Dim.	Pole	Label
1	pos	Discourse of Political and Emotional Outrage, Moral Indictment, and Ideological Slogan
	neg	Descriptive Discourse of Visual Objects, Attire, and Physical Props
2	pos	Discourse of Civic Preparedness, Institutional Action, and Moral Commitment to Society
	neg	Descriptive Discourse of Physical Human Detail
3	pos	Discourse of Global Diplomacy, Dialog, Cooperation, and Moral Legitimacy
	neg	Descriptive Discourse of Large Structures and Landscapes

Dimension 1

Dimension 1: Loadings

Pos. pole (N=194: Discourse of Political and Emotional Outrage, Moral Indictment, and Ideological Slogan)

accusatory (.79), anger (.76), indignation (.75), condemnation (.73), harmful (.72), intensify (.72), outrage (.71), disapproval (.71), dissatisfaction (.70), negative (.70), accusation (.69), genocidal (.69), political (.69), mismanagement (.68), oppose (.68), wrongdoing (.67), author (.67), corruption (.67), v000583 (.67), accuse (.67), severe (.67), conjunction (.66), alleged (.66), polarization (.66), genocide (.66), accompanying (.66), target (.65), negligence (.65), discontent (.65), polarized (.65), ...

Neg. pole (N=83: Descriptive Discourse of Visual Objects, Attire, and Physical Props)

skullcap (-.77), gold (-.73), elaborate (-.72), pin (-.70), metallic (-.69), lapel (-.66), decor (-.66), negotiation (-.66), (blazer (-.64)), (sunlight (-.63)), illuminate (-.60), colored (-.59), sleeveless (-.59), (indistinct (-.59)), (afternoon (-.58)), (caucasian (-.57)), hue (-.57), interior (-.57), (curly (-.57)), (planning (-.57)), (neck (-.56)), diversity (-.55), (pants (-.54)), (grassy (-.54)), foliage (-.54), (angle (-.53)), (necklace (-.52)), (blouse (-.51)), diamond (-.51), (vegetation (-.50)), ...

Mean Dim. 1 Scores

Discourse of Political and Emotional Outrage, Moral Indictment, and Ideological Slogan vs. Descriptive Discourse of Visual Objects, Attire, and Physical Props

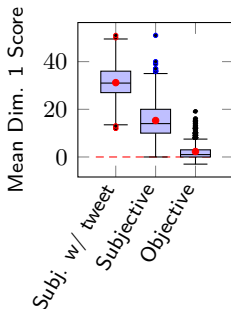


Figure: Mean Dim. 1 Scores by Condition ($F=5535.287$, $df=2,2717$, $p=0.000000$, $R^2 = 80.3\%$)

Image 1: Pos. Dim. 1

Discourse of Political and Emotional Outrage, Moral Indictment, and Ideological Slogan



Tweet 1: Pos. Dim. 1

Discourse of Political and Emotional Outrage, Moral Indictment, and Ideological Slogan

2020-04-29; translation

@Marinasilva A psychopath in power, followed by a herd of creeps without decency and character, who treat politics like barroom talk. The difference here is that lives are lost in vain because of genocidal discourse. Meanwhile, @houseofrepresentatives is for sale. #6Bolsonaroscrimes <https://t.co/wwyhnw7ps7>

2020-04-29; original

@MarinaSilva Um psicopata no poder, seguido por uma manada d asquerosos sem decência e caráter, q tratam política como discussão d buteco sobre futebol. A diferença aqui é q vidas se perdem em vão por causa d um discurso genocida. Enquanto isso, @camaradeputados a venda. #6CrimesDoBolsonaro <https://t.co/wWyHNw7Ps7>

All Excerpts 1: Pos. Dim. 1

Discourse of Political and Emotional Outrage, Moral Indictment, and Ideological Slogan

Subj. with Tweet; Score=51.000

The image **associated** with the tweet is a **stark**, high-contrast black-and-white depiction featuring three **figures** with an ominous ram 's skull positioned strategically above the central **figure**, suggesting a dark or menacing aura. The central **figure** is shown with exaggerated and grim facial features, which, along with the positioning of the ram 's skull, may symbolize a sinister or malign influence.

Subjective; Score=17.000

The image, rendered in high-contrast black and white, conveys **strong emotional** and potentially **political** messaging through its surreal and striking composition. It depicts a central **figure** with what appears to be a ram 's head superimposed or merging with his own, flanked by two other **figures** whose faces are overlaid or transformed with similar sheep or ram features. The **use** of animal **imagery** superimposed on human **figures** might symbolize a loss of individuality, herd mentality, or blind following, all of which are potent metaphors in **political discourse**.

Objective; Score=5.000

The image is a high-contrast, black and white graphic that features three male faces. It appears to be stylistically altered, possibly for an artistic or graphic purpose, with sharp edges and **stark** contrasts that highlight only the most essential outlines and features of the faces and their expressions. Two of the faces are partially obscured and appear in the background, while the central **figure** is detailed and front-facing with a prominent expression.

Image 2: Neg. Dim. 1

Descriptive Discourse of Visual Objects, Attire, and Physical Props



All Excerpts 2: Neg. Dim. 1

Descriptive Discourse of Visual Objects, Attire, and Physical Props

Subj. with Tweet; Score=26.000

The image depicts a distinguished man speaking at the United Nations General Assembly podium, given the distinctive green marble background and the UN emblem. His serious expression and formal attire—a dark suit and a tie—convey a sense of gravitas and authority. The setting suggests the importance of the speech he is delivering, possibly addressing international leaders on significant global issues.

Subjective; Score=9.000

This image depicts a man speaking at the United Nations General Assembly, one of the most significant platforms in international diplomacy and **policy-making**. His grave facial expression and formal attire suggest the seriousness of the occasion. The setting, with the iconic green marble rostrum and the emblem of the United Nations in the background, emphasizes the global importance of the venue and the weight of the decisions and discussions that take place there.

Objective; Score=-2.000

The image shows a man standing behind a lectern in a formal setting, specifically at the United Nations General Assembly hall. He is dressed in a dark suit and tie, with a **pin** on his left **lapel**. The man has a **thick**, graying beard and mustache. The lectern has a placard with the United Nations emblem on it. The backdrop features the iconic green marble of the UN General Assembly.

Dimension 2

Dimension 2: Loadings

Pos. pole (N=117: Discourse of Civic Preparedness, Institutional Action, and Moral Commitment to Society)

preparedness (.86), ensure (.79), planning (.78), anxiety (.74), funding (.70), readiness (.70), ability (.68), reassurance (.67), remind (.65), access (.65), policy-making (.64), local (.64), resource (.63), balance (.61), citizen (.61), unease (.60), reminder (.57), civic (.56), manage (.56), resilience (.56), need (.56), participation (.55), safety (.55), capability (.53), society (.53), civil (.52), collective (.52), effort (.52), sovereignty (.51), pride (.51), ...

Neg. pole (N=100: Descriptive Discourse of Physical Human Detail)

short (-.91), hair (-.85), brown (-.84), neck (-.78), mustache (-.75), beard (-.72), blazer (-.67), skin (-.66), floral (-.66), curly (-.66), light-colored (-.66), middle-aged (-.66), blouse (-.62), (lapel (-.61)), collar (-.61), indistinct (-.60), wall (-.60), watermark (-.59), dark (-.59), (decor (-.58)), caucasian (-.58), (pin (-.58)), decorative (-.58), ornate (-.57), indoor (-.57), necklace (-.56), grey (-.56), upper (-.56), gray (-.56), shirt (-.56), ...

Mean Dim. 2 Scores

Discourse of Civic Preparedness, Institutional Action, and Moral Commitment to Society vs. Descriptive Discourse of Physical Human Detail

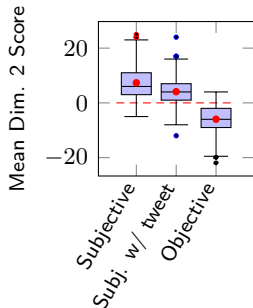


Figure: Mean Dim. 2 Scores by Condition ($F=2007.538$, $df=2,2717$, $p=0.000000$, $R^2 = 59.6\%$)

Image 1: Pos. Dim. 2

Discourse of Civic Preparedness, Institutional Action, and Moral Commitment to Society



Tweet 1: Pos. Dim. 2

Discourse of Civic Preparedness, Institutional Action, and Moral Commitment to Society

2021-02-26; translation

Avoid institutional rupture.  Collor asked for yellow-green support, but population took to the streets wearing black/92 Bolsonaro discourages use of face masks, let's take it to the streets urgently against genocide. For our safety, we will wear protection gear. With the right protection, we can do it/2021 <https://t.co/pynrqImarX>

2021-02-26; original

EVITAR RUPTURA INSTITUCIONAL.  Collor pediu apoio em verde-amarelo, mas população saiu às ruas de preto/92 BOLSONARO DESESTIMULA USO D MÁCARA, OCUPAR AS RUAS (MANIFESTAR) URGENTE CONTRA O GENOCIDA. P/NOSSA GARANTIA, IREMOS PARAMENTADOS SEM RISCO. C/TODA PROTEÇÃO, NÓS PODEMOS/2021 <https://t.co/PynrqIMARX>

All Excerpts 1: Pos. Dim. 2

Discourse of Civic Preparedness, Institutional Action, and Moral Commitment to Society

Subj. with Tweet; Score=10.000

The image shows an individual dressed in protective medical gear, which includes a facemask, face shield, gloves, and a disposable gown. The person is pointing with both hands, suggesting directions or guidance. The expression on the person's face, partially covered by the mask, looks serious and focused, effectively **underscoring** the **urgency** and gravity conveyed in the accompanying tweet. The tweet itself references significant political unrest and health **concerns**, drawing parallels between historical political demonstrations and current events (as of 2021) related to the COVID-19 pandemic and the actions (or

Subjective; Score=25.000

The image portrays a healthcare worker dressed in protective gear, including a face mask, face shield, gloves, and a disposable gown. The worker's expression, though obscured by the mask, appears focused and serious, possibly indicative of the gravity and **urgency often experienced** by medical professionals, **especially** during health **crises** like the COVID-19 pandemic. Emotionally, the image can **evoke feelings** of **reassurance** and **trust**, as it **highlights** the thorough precautions being taken to **ensure safety** and cleanliness.

Objective; Score=-6.000

This image features an individual dressed in protective medical gear against a plain, light background. The person is wearing a white coverall, blue gloves, a face mask, face shield, and a hairnet. They are pointing with both hands towards different directions and looking directly at the camera. The overall setting suggests a clinical or health **safety** environment.

Image 5: Neg. Dim. 2

Descriptive Discourse of Physical Human Detail



Tweet 5: Neg. Dim. 2

Descriptive Discourse of Physical Human Detail

2022-02-27; translation

Someone needs to stop this criminal! The world cannot be hostage to a genocidal, inhuman, fascist, murderous, outlaw, unscrupulous person. He now threatens the whole world like Hitler.

2022-02-27; original

Alguém precisa parar esse criminoso! O mundo não pode ser refém de um genocida, desumano, fascista, assassino, facínora, sem escrúpulos. Ele agora ameaça como Hitler o mundo todo.

All Excerpts 5: Neg. Dim. 2

Descriptive Discourse of Physical Human Detail

Subj. with Tweet; Score=3.000

The image depicts Vladimir Putin in a formal setting, **seated** at a desk with a **microphones**, gesturing with his right **hand**. He appears serious and focused, which is consistent with the portrayal one might expect of a political leader in a significant or intense discussion. The emotional impact of seeing this image alongside the tweet, which harshly criticizes Putin, invokes a strong sentiment.

Subjective; Score=1.000

The image shows a **man**, presumably a high-ranking official or leader, gesturing with his **hand** while engaging in what seems to be a serious conversation or making a point in a discussion. He is dressed formally in a **suit** and **tie**, **seated** at a table with a **microphone**, suggesting the setting of a formal meeting or press conference. Emotionally, the **man** 's expression is stern and resolute, conveying a sense of determination or intensity.

Objective; Score=-17.000

The image shows a **middle-aged man** with very short, **light brown hair**, dressed in a **dark suit**, **light blue shirt**, and a **red tie** with a small **pattern**. He appears to be in a formal setting, **seated** at a desk with a **microphone** in front of him. His expression is serious and he is gesturing with his right **hand**, possibly making a point during a discussion or speech.

Dimension 3

Dimension 3: Loadings

Pos. pole (N=126: Discourse of Global Diplomacy, Dialog, Cooperation, and Moral Legitimacy)

mutual (.91), warmth (.80), relatable (.78), diplomacy (.77), respect (.75), cooperation (.73), humanize (.69), confidence (.67), constituent (.64), transcend (.64), sphere (.63), shared (.63), relationship (.63), project (.63), important (.59), trust (.58), unity (.58), (negotiation (.57)), appeal (.56), cultural (.56), relation (.56), inspire (.55), accessibility (.54), crucial (.54), foster (.54), reassure (.53), shape (.53), (diversity (.52)), solemnity (.51), commitment (.51), ...

Neg. pole (N=74: Descriptive Discourse of Large Structures and Landscapes)

vegetation (-.84), park (-.81), sunlight (-.80), partly (-.80), tree (-.80), sunny (-.77), wing (-.77), afternoon (-.75), dirt (-.74), accent (-.74), airport (-.69), road (-.69), angle (-.68), tarmac (-.66), cloudy (-.63), sky (-.63), grassy (-.62), (metallic (-.61)), pants (-.60), tail (-.60), thin (-.57), orange (-.57), overcast (-.56), section (-.56), paved (-.54), shadow (-.53), stripe (-.53), (foliage (-.52)), greenery (-.51), patch (-.51), ...

Mean Dim. 3 Scores

Discourse of Global Diplomacy, Dialog, Cooperation, and Moral Legitimacy vs. Descriptive Discourse of Large Structures and Landscapes

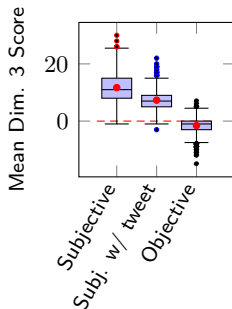


Figure: Mean Dim. 3 Scores by Condition ($F=2549.486$, $df=2,2717$, $p=0.000000$, $R^2 = 65.2\%$)

Image 8: Pos. Dim. 3

Discourse of Global Diplomacy, Dialog, Cooperation, and Moral Legitimacy



Tweet 8: Pos. Dim. 3

Discourse of Global Diplomacy, Dialog, Cooperation, and Moral Legitimacy

2019-05-13; translation

The Pope is a communist and a card-carrying fan of rotten genocidal Maduro

2019-05-13; original

O papa é comunista e fã de carteirinha do genocida Maduro podre

All Excerpts 8: Pos. Dim. 3

Discourse of Global Diplomacy, Dialog, Cooperation, and Moral Legitimacy

Subj. with Tweet; Score=8.000

The image shows Pope Francis laughing or calling out, his face expressing joviality and openness. He is dressed in the traditional white cassock associated with the Pope, which signifies purity and his **role** as the head of the Catholic Church. His gesture, where he has his hand cupped around his mouth, might normally suggest he is either shouting or sharing an enthusiastic message.

Subjective; Score=25.000

The image depicts a man dressed in religious attire, specifically the white robe and skullcap known to be worn by the Pope, the **leader** of the Roman Catholic Church. He is captured in a joyful **moment**, smiling broadly and cupping his hand to his mouth as if to shout or **project** his voice. This expression and gesture **convey warmth**, openness, and a **sense of connection** with his **audience**, suggesting his approachability and charisma.

Objective; Score=2.000

The image shows an elderly man dressed in white religious attire, including a white skullcap. He appears joyful and is holding his right hand to his mouth, seemingly shouting or calling out loudly. The background is blurred but suggests an outdoor setting with a light-colored backdrop, likely a building. The man's expression, coupled with his animated gesture, **conveys** a **sense** of enthusiasm or **engagement** with an **audience** not visible in the frame.

Image 5: Neg. Dim. 3

Descriptive Discourse of Environments and Landscapes



Tweet 5: Neg. Dim. 3

Descriptive Discourse of Environments and Landscapes

2022-12-30; translation

Photo for the history books. About how a genocidal and corrupt government comes to an end
<https://t.co/RixBSGAV7W>

2022-12-30; original

Foto para os livros de história. Sobre como se acaba um governo genocida e corrupto <https://t.co/RixbSGAV7w>

All Excerpts 5: Neg. Dim. 3

Descriptive Discourse of Environments and Landscapes

Subj. with Tweet; Score=5.000

The image shows an airplane ascending into a **cloudy sky**, viewed from behind a wire fence, possibly symbolizing departure or escape. Given the context provided by the tweet, the image carries significant emotional and political weight. The phrase " Foto para os livros de história " suggests that the moment captured is of historical importance, perhaps signaling a pivotal change related to the end of a government described as " genocida e corrupto " (genocidal and corrupt).

Subjective; Score=6.000

The image depicts an airplane taking off beyond a perimeter fence, suggestive of being viewed from a place of restricted or no access. The framing with the chain-link fence in the **foreground** introduces a powerful emotional contrast: the sense of freedom and escape symbolized by the airborne airplane against the confining, grounded perspective of the viewer. Emotionally, the image could evoke a mix of aspiration and melancholy.

Objective; Score=-11.000

The image captures an airplane in mid-flight, ascending against a **cloudy sky** background. The airplane, **predominantly** white with **yellow** and blue **accents**, is positioned in the **top** central **portion** of the image. The **foreground** features a **blurred** chain-link fence at the **bottom**, subtly hinting that the viewpoint is from outside an **airport** or a restricted area. Scene features also include **trees** and radio towers, likely part of the **airport** 's surrounding infrastructure.

Conclusion

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Conclusion

- Subjective mode reflects a rosy, romantic, worldview: dialog, cooperation, civic action, and legitimacy.
- Objective mode flattens meaning into surface-level visual description.
- Tweet-based subjectivity is unstable — the model often misses layered meanings.
- LLM-generated texts offer an entry point for multimodal analysis: turning images into corpus data.

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